RESOLUTION No. 7313

Grades 6-12 Social Studies Curriculum Materials Adoption

RECITALS

A. Standards-aligned instruction supported by a balanced curriculum ensures every student has the opportunity to access a rigorous education that prepares them for college, career, and active civic life. An inquiry-based, student-centered approach to social studies curriculum and instruction—deeply rooted in the framework established by the 2024 Oregon Social Studies Standards—shifts pedagogy away from traditional models toward active student inquiry, proving highly effective in closing the opportunity gap.

B. For Portland Public Schools, a strong 6-12 Social Studies curriculum and instruction includes four key elements based on best practices:

    a. The Inquiry Arc: Standards aligned with state and national requirements that move past rote memorization toward constructing compelling questions, applying disciplinary concepts (history, civics, economics, and geography), evaluating primary/secondary sources, and communicating data-backed conclusions.

    b. Inclusive Histories: Core curriculum materials that systematically center the resilience, resistance, agency, and contemporary contributions of Black, Indigenous, Latine, Asian American, Pacific Islander, and LGBTQ+ communities, moving entirely away from monthly add-ons.

    c. Universal Design and Complex Texts: High-quality resources designed around Universal Design for Learning (UDL) that provide integrated literacy scaffolds, vocabulary tiering, and multimedia extensions so that Multilingual Learners and students receiving Special Education services can critically analyze authentic texts alongside their peers.

    d. Standards-Aligned Assessments: Tools and performance tasks that allow educators to periodically evaluate student progress towards state standards and monitor alignment with post-secondary success indicators.

C. A comprehensive field-testing period spanning the 2025–2026 school year was central to this adoption process to replace materials last adopted several years ago. This teacher-led, data-driven initiative involved approximately 40 PAT educators from across six middle schools and nine high schools—including NAYA and specialists in Special Education and Dual Language Immersion (DLI)—who utilized the Instructional Resource Bias Evaluation tool to narrow five potential vendors down to those scoring highest.

D. The field test and evaluation process resulted in strong, data-backed recommendations to close the current resource gap and establish a vertically articulated pathway from Western/Eastern Hemispheres in middle school to Modern World History, US History, Government, and Economics in high school:

a. For grades 6-8, the pilot of TCi materials resulted in 100% teacher approval (55% "Highly Recommend", 45% "Recommend with Reservations"), with 80.5% of middle school students reporting a "Just Right" level of difficulty.

b. For grades 9-12, the pilot resulted in an 84% teacher approval rating for the final recommendation, with Cengage achieving 91% teacher validation for asset-based representation.

c. Teachers formally vetted materials for Canvas and Synergy compatibility, noting that literacy scaffolds received an 82% favorable rating in Modern World History and 72% in US History.

d. The selection of vendors such as TCi and Cengage successfully addresses a critical need identified during the field test by providing translated materials for the district's 1,000+ Spanish DLI students, ensuring equitable content without relying on inaccurate machine translations.

E. Throughout this collaborative process, Portland Public School staff prioritized quantitative and qualitative stakeholder feedback, collecting surveys from 938 students in total—resulting in a 93% favorable sentiment rating among high school students and 84.2% among middle school students regarding keeping the curriculum. Engagement included direct meetings with the Student Action Committee, classroom visits, and targeted public review consisting of:

a. Publicly noticed meetings of the Teaching, Learning, and Enrollment Committee, where formal public comments were accepted and reviewed.

b. Dedicated in-person community events and asynchronous digital reviews, allowing families to engage directly with resources, speak with vendor representatives, and collaboratively discuss curriculum limitations to ensure alignment with district equity standards.

F. The Social Studies adoption committee has reviewed materials for grades 6-12 and completed an evaluation, resulting in a specific recommendation to the Superintendent to adopt TCi (6-8 and HS Economics), Cengage (Modern World History, US History, and Government), and The Cultural Landscape (AP Human Geography). This adoption directly supports Board Goal #3 (8th-grade proficiency) and Board Goal #4 (post-secondary indicators for underserved students) by fostering an asset-based identity for students of color and helping Multilingual Learners meet rigorous graduation requirements.

G. The Teaching, Learning, and Enrollment Committee reviewed this recommendation, noting that deployment and vendor-led professional development focusing on inquiry-based simulations and digital literacy tools will begin in August 2026.

RESOLUTION

1. The Board of Education accepts the Superintendent’s recommendation to adopt and purchase the recommended 6-12 Social Studies instructional materials (TCi, Cengage, and The Cultural Landscape) for the 2026–2027 school year.

2. The Board of Education acknowledges that this comprehensive adoption streamlines lesson planning and preparation for educators, mitigates historical inconsistencies, and ensures district-wide continuity for students.

3. The Board further acknowledges that this purchase will be responsibly funded through a combination of the 2020 School Bond (covering physical and digital student/teacher materials) and General Funds (supporting ongoing professional development, pacing guides, and implementation resources).

4. The Board of Education emphasizes that student access to approved, high-quality instructional materials is a foundational pillar of our district strategy for systemic educational equity.

5. The Board of Education thanks the pilot teachers, specialists, the Student Action Committee, and community members for their intensive work and the time commitment it represents, and commends them for their service to the students of Portland Public Schools.